

2024 was the hottest year — 2025 could be hotter

The jury is still out on whether climate change has reached a point of no return. But the India Meteorological Department's (IMD) **announcement** that in 2024, the world's most **populous** country experienced its hottest year since 1901 **should** be **sobering** for **policymakers** across the world. Globally, too, there is enough evidence that the year **gone by** was the hottest on record — though the World Meteorological Organisation (WMO) has not yet issued an official declaration. The IMD and WMO have warned that 2025 could be another hot year. **By all accounts**, India is on track to **meet** its global climate goals. That, however, isn't the case for most countries, especially those in the West. Indian policymakers must, therefore, build several **guardrails** — frame heat action plans, build sea walls, improve disaster-management systems, **spruce up** weather-alert **mechanisms**, **overhaul** drainage systems, install irrigation systems to **combat** water **scarcity** and climate-proof agriculture.

As the planet gets hotter, the challenge will be to **address** people's **vulnerabilities** without **compromising** on their developmental needs. More than 30 per cent of the country's GDP is generated in sectors that are highly nature-dependent — agriculture, forestry, water and power utilities, and construction. A World Economic Forum study estimates that agriculture output is estimated to drop by 16 per cent in the next five years, **shaving off** more than 2.5 per cent of the GDP. Another **report**, last year, by the global construction consultancy CBRE, **estimates** that nearly 50 per cent of the country's infrastructure is at risk due to extreme weather events. The Reserve Bank of India has also recognised that **global warming** can **upset** financial stability and growth. **Quantification** of climate risks in the country has, however, been **patchy**, largely because of the **fragmented** nature of information and **widespread variations** in data collection metrics. In this context, the RBI's **move**, last year, to **set up** a **repository**, the Climate Risk Information System, **is** a timely step. The system's focus on local-level **scenarios** is particularly **salient given** that climate vulnerabilities vary every few kilometres in the country.

The political class has, however, rarely **taken cues** from the country's central bank, Met body, academia and civil society institutions. **The toll taken** by floods, **landslides**, sea-level rise, poor air and the loss of green lungs **has** rarely been at the centre of political conversation, even during the general election last year. That's why **longstanding** vulnerabilities of people to extreme rainfall, heat and cold have remained **unaddressed**. Every year, floods in rural and urban India **expose** a similar set of **abdications**: **Outdated** drainage systems that cannot take the stress of more than normal rainfall, planning that does not **account for** local **hydrology** and civic agencies whose role seems limited to organising relief and rescue. It's increasingly becoming clear that floods, **droughts**, cyclones and heatwaves cannot be **dealt with** on a short-term basis, or only to **tide over** emergencies. **[Practice Ex.]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

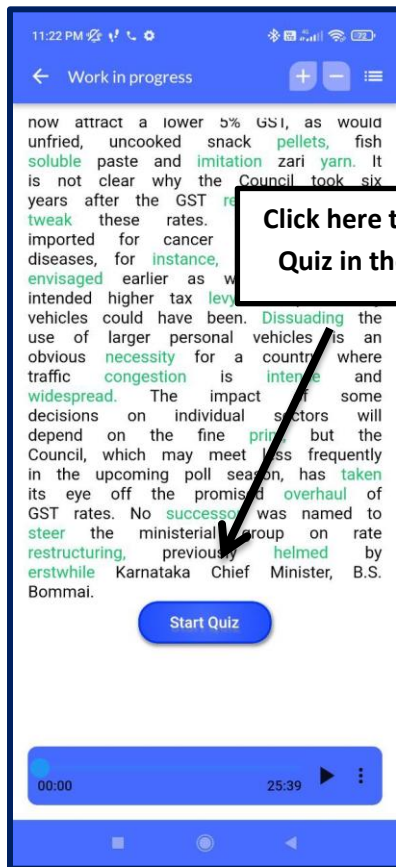
1. **The jury is out** (phrase) – Undecided, uncertain, unresolved, inconclusive निर्णय नहीं हुआ
2. **Populous** (adjective) – Densely populated, crowded, heavily inhabited घनी आबादी वाला
3. **Sobering** (adjective) – Serious, alarming, thought-provoking, disconcerting चिंताजनक
4. **Policymaker** (noun) – Legislator, decision-maker, strategist, administrator नीति निर्माता
5. **Go by** (phrasal verb) – (used about time) to pass (समय का) गुज़रना
6. **By all accounts** (phrase) – According to reports, as stated by everyone, by every indication सभी के अनुसार
7. **Meet** (verb) – Fulfill, satisfy, achieve, adhere to पूरा करना
8. **Guardrail** (noun) – Safety measure, protective barrier, safeguard सुरक्षा अवरोधक
9. **Spruce up** (phrasal verb) – Improve, renovate, enhance, tidy up सुधारना
10. **Mechanism** (noun) – System, process, method, framework तंत्र
11. **Overhaul** (verb) – Revamp, rebuild, refurbish, rework पूरी तरह सुधार करना
12. **Combat** (verb) – Fight, counter, tackle, address मुकाबला करना
13. **Scarcity** (noun) – Shortage, lack, insufficiency, dearth कमी
14. **Address** (verb) – Deal with, tackle, resolve, attend to समाधान करना
15. **Vulnerability** (noun) – Susceptibility, exposure, weakness, fragility संवेदनशीलता
16. **Compromise** (verb) – Endanger, jeopardize, weaken, dilute समझौता करना
17. **Shave off** (phrasal verb) – Reduce, cut down, trim, decrease कम करना
18. **Global warming** (noun) – the increase in the temperature of the earth's atmosphere, caused by the increase of certain gases वैश्विक ऊष्मीकरण
19. **Upset** (verb) – Disturb, disrupt, unsettle, shake up बाधित करना
20. **Quantification** (noun) – Measurement, assessment, calculation, evaluation मात्राकरण
21. **Patchy** (adjective) – Uneven, inconsistent, irregular, spotty असमान

22. **Fragmented** (adjective) – Divided, broken, disjointed, incomplete खंडित
23. **Widespread** (adjective) – Extensive, prevalent, ubiquitous, far-reaching व्यापक
24. **Variation** (noun) – Difference, change, fluctuation, divergence अंतर
25. **Set up** (phrasal verb) – Establish, create, initiate, launch स्थापित करना
26. **Repository** (noun) – Storage, archive, depository, reserve भंडार
27. **Scenario** (noun) – Situation, case, possibility, circumstance परिदृश्य
28. **Salient** (adjective) – Prominent, significant, notable, key प्रमुख
29. **Given** (preposition) – Considering, taking into account, in view of देखते हुए
30. **Take cue** (phrase) – Follow example, derive inspiration, act upon संकेत लेना
31. **Take a toll** (phrase) – Cause damage, inflict harm, have a negative effect नुकसान पहुंचाना
32. **Landslide** (noun) – Earthfall, mudslide, rockslide, avalanche भूस्खलन
33. **Longstanding** (adjective) – Enduring, long-term, persistent, established दीर्घकालिक
34. **Unaddressed** (adjective) – Ignored, unresolved, unattended, neglected ध्यान न दिया गया
35. **Expose** (verb) – Reveal, uncover, disclose, make visible उजागर करना
36. **Abdication** (noun) – Neglect, relinquishment, renunciation, resignation त्याग
37. **Outdated** (adjective) – Obsolete, old-fashioned, antiquated, archaic पुराना
38. **Account for** (phrasal verb) – Constitute, represent, comprise, make up, form के लिये उत्तरदयी होना
39. **Hydrology** (noun) – Study of water, water science, aquatic studies जलविज्ञान
40. **Drought** (noun) – Dry spell, water shortage, aridity, scarcity सूखा
41. **Deal with** (phrasal verb) – Handle, address, manage, tackle निपटना
42. **Tide over** (phrasal verb) – Overcome, manage, survive, get through पार करना

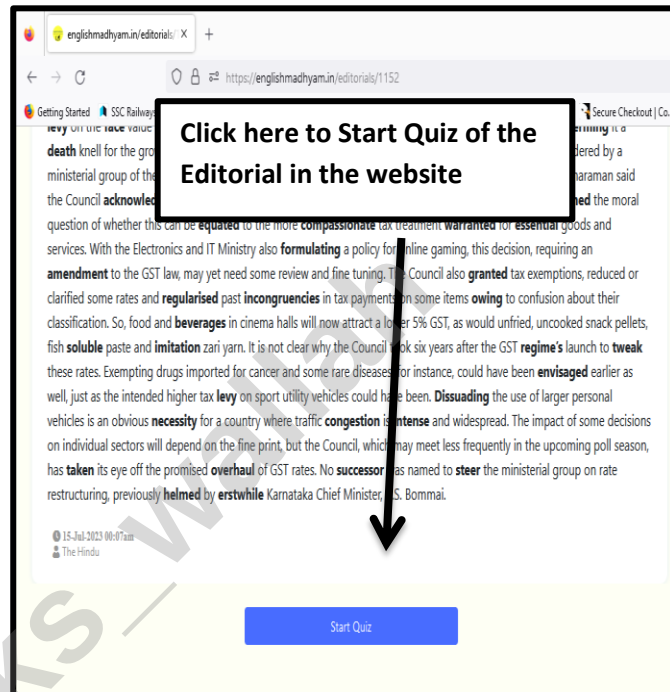
Summary of the Editorial

1. **2024: Hottest Year on Record:** India experienced its hottest year since 1901, with global evidence pointing to 2024 as the hottest year globally, although the WMO's official declaration is awaited.
2. **2025 Warning:** Both the IMD and WMO predict that 2025 could surpass 2024 in terms of extreme temperatures.
3. **India's Climate Goals:** While India is on track to meet its global climate goals, many countries, particularly in the West, lag behind.
4. **Necessary Guardrails:** India must focus on framing heat action plans, building sea walls, improving disaster management, enhancing weather-alert systems, and climate-proofing agriculture.
5. **Vulnerable GDP Sectors:** Over 30% of India's GDP comes from climate-sensitive sectors like agriculture, forestry, and water, which are increasingly at risk.
6. **Agricultural Risks:** A WEF study projects a 16% drop in agricultural output in the next five years, reducing GDP by over 2.5%.
7. **Infrastructure at Risk:** Nearly 50% of India's infrastructure is vulnerable to extreme weather, according to a CBRE report.
8. **Financial Stability Threat:** The RBI acknowledges that global warming poses risks to financial stability and economic growth.
9. **Climate Risk Data:** Data on climate risks in India is fragmented, leading to inconsistencies in assessing vulnerabilities.
10. **RBI's Initiative:** The Climate Risk Information System set up by the RBI focuses on local-level scenarios, addressing variations in climate vulnerabilities across regions.
11. **Lack of Political Focus:** Climate-related challenges like floods, heatwaves, and rising sea levels have not been central to political discussions, including during elections.
12. **Recurring Issues:** Annual floods highlight persistent issues such as outdated drainage systems, poor planning, and ineffective civic responses.
13. **Neglected Vulnerabilities:** Vulnerabilities to extreme weather remain unaddressed, exacerbating the impact of heatwaves, floods, and droughts.
14. **Beyond Short-Term Responses:** Managing climate disasters requires long-term planning rather than reactive, emergency-based approaches.
15. **Urgent Action Needed:** Policymakers must prioritize systemic changes to address climate challenges comprehensively, ensuring sustainability while meeting developmental needs.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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